SPRINT 1

The Map

Before we build, we understand.

PRODUCT	MARKET	TIMELINE	GOAL
StartupKit	**USA Only**	**Days 1–15**	**Research the full US founder journey**

— NAVIGATION

Contents

— SECTION 01

Why This Sprint Exists

StartupKit exists because starting a company in the USA is genuinely hard to navigate — not because the information does not exist, but because it exists everywhere, disagrees with itself, is not sequenced, and is not personalised to where a specific founder actually is. A first-time founder today can spend three weeks reading contradictory Reddit threads about LLC vs C-Corp and still not know what to do. Our job is to fix that.

Sprint 1 — The Map — is a research sprint, not a build sprint. Before a single line of product code is written, we need a complete, verified, sourced map of the entire US founder journey. Every feature, every screen, every piece of guidance StartupKit produces will trace back to this research. Get this wrong and we build a beautiful product on top of bad assumptions. Get this right and the product almost writes itself.

22% of US businesses fail in year one (BLS, 2024–25 cohort)	**65%** are gone by year ten (BLS Business Employment Dynamics)	**74%** of failures caused by premature scaling (Startup Genome, 3,200 startups)	**15%** seed-to-Series-A graduation rate (Carta, 2022 vintage, 2yr window)

These numbers are not abstractions. They are the context in which every founder who lands on StartupKit is operating. The research we produce in Sprint 1 is our answer to them — a map that helps founders avoid the traps that produced those statistics.

The 30-day rule that ruins lives

The 83(b) election under IRC §83 must be filed within 30 calendar days of restricted-stock grant. There are no extensions, no cure, and no reasonable-cause exceptions. A founder who misses this deadline on 1,000,000 shares and vests through $20/share can face millions of dollars in phantom income tax on stock they cannot sell. This is one of hundreds of stage-specific landmines StartupKit's research must surface before founders walk into them — not after.

— SECTION 02

What StartupKit Is

StartupKit is a guided, step-by-step product that takes a founder from raw idea to an operational, fundable US company. It is not a course, a bank, a law firm, or a chatbot. It is the navigation layer sitting above the existing ecosystem. Stripe Atlas handles incorporation. Clerky handles paperwork. Carta manages the cap table. Mercury provides banking. Y Combinator Startup School teaches the philosophy. None of them — individually or combined — tells a founder *what to do next, why, and when* across the whole journey. That gap is StartupKit's territory.

The core design hypothesis: Founder success is gated less by access to information — there is an abundance — and more by sequencing, judgment, and definition-of-done at each stage. A first-time founder asking 'Should I form an LLC or a C-Corp?' on Reddit will get fifty answers in fifteen minutes. None will tell them whether this question is even what they should be solving today. StartupKit's job is to be the calm, opinionated, sourced guide that answers both the surface question and the meta-question.

The product in one sentence

You tell StartupKit your situation once. It shows you exactly what to do next — in the right order, with the right context, nothing irrelevant — like a GPS for your startup journey.

USA only — why the constraint matters

StartupKit v1 covers the US market exclusively. This is a deliberate constraint, not a limitation. The US startup ecosystem — Delaware C-Corps, IRS EINs, 83(b) elections, YC SAFEs, NVCA documents, Silicon Valley angels, Stripe Atlas — has enough specificity to fill a product. Adding UK, EU, or Pakistan law in v1 would produce a product that is mediocre everywhere instead of definitive somewhere. USA first, done properly.

— SECTION 03

The Research Problem — Why Quality Matters

Three properties of this research domain make quality non-negotiable.

1. Founders pattern-match for credibility instantly

A founder who has read Paul Graham, Geoff Ralston, and the Clerky Handbook can tell within one screen whether a product respects the canon or is regurgitating SEO content. If StartupKit's content quality does not clear the bar set by YC's library, Clerky's handbook, and Stripe Atlas's guides, the most informed users — exactly the users whose word-of-mouth we need — will bounce in seconds and never return.

2. Factual errors in this domain are dangerous, not embarrassing

Wrong information here has real financial and legal consequences. A missed 83(b) can cost a founder millions. Recommending an LLC to a VC-backed startup creates $10,000–$35,000 in conversion legal fees. Confusing pre-money and post-money SAFE mechanics can hand 10 extra points of dilution to investors. The research we produce will be relied upon by real founders making irreversible decisions.

3. The market moves — nothing is evergreen

Techstars changed their standard deal from $120K-for-6% to $220K total in 2025. The IRS released standardised Form 15620 for 83(b) elections in April 2025. The One Big Beautiful Bill Act (July 2025) lifted the QSBS per-issuer exclusion cap from $10M to $15M. NVCA model documents were revised in October 2025. Every research artifact produced in this sprint must carry an 'as-of' date and a note on what changed and when.

The quality bar is the Clerky Handbook

Read handbooks.clerky.com from start to finish before producing any research brief. Every paragraph is short. Every term is defined inline. Every recommendation is explicit. Every scope limitation is stated upfront. Every claim is sourced. That is the voice StartupKit aims to match.

A bad research brief reads like an SEO article: hedged, undated, sourced to other content sites, padded with definitions, no recommendation, no acknowledged conflicts. If a draft sounds like it was written by an AI summarising a Google search, it needs another pass.

— SECTION 04

The 11-Stage US Startup Journey

The journey is not a waterfall. Stages overlap, founders skip and revisit, and the sequence shifts by startup type. What follows is the canonical model — the spine every StartupKit module will attach to. Treat it as overlapping waves, not a checklist.

0 Pre-founder

Weeks to years

- Live at the edge of a domain
- Accumulate problems in a notebook
- Co-founder conversations

1 Customer Discovery

2–8 weeks

- 15–30 customer interviews (Mom Test)
- Get out of the building
- Evidence of current workarounds

2 Problem-Solution Fit

2–6 weeks

- Concierge or Wizard-of-Oz tests
- Commitment-and-advancement asks
- Letters of intent

3 MVP Build

2–12 weeks

- Smallest thing delivering core value
- Manual user recruitment
- Instrumented for usage

4 First Revenue

1–6 months

- Founder-led sales
- 10 paying customers
- First dollar of revenue

5 Legal Formation

1–4 weeks

- Delaware C-Corp or LLC filing
- EIN, bank account
- 83(b) filed within 30 days ■

6 Early Hiring

6–18 months

- Contractor-first approach
- 10–15% option pool pre-seed
- PIIA signed before day 1

7 Pre-seed

2–8 weeks active

- $750K–$1.5M on SAFE
- $6–10M post-money cap
- Friends, angels, micro-VCs

8 Seed Round

4–12 weeks active

- Median $3.1M raised
- Median $20–24M post-money
- ~20% dilution (Carta 2025)

9 Product-Market Fit

6–24 months

- 40% 'very disappointed' test
- Flat cohort retention
- NPS > 40 for SaaS

10 Series A

4–10 weeks active

- $10–15M raise
- $57–78M post-money
- ~$2.5M ARR threshold (CRV)

Note: Stages 5–7 frequently overlap with Stages 2–4. Many founders incorporate (Stage 5) before they have revenue (Stage 4). The diagram above represents the canonical sequence; real journeys are messier.

— SECTION 05

The Competitor Landscape

Understanding what already exists is essential before designing StartupKit. The competitive landscape is rich but fragmented — every existing product solves one part of the journey, not the whole. The gap StartupKit occupies is the navigation layer that connects all of them.

Product	Covers	Strengths	Gap / Weakness
Stripe Atlas *stripe.com/atlas*	**Incorporatio n**	1-in-6 new Delaware C-Corps in 2024 went through Atlas. Covers filing, EIN, founder equity, 83(b), and first-year RA. Guides explain every clause. Best UX in the space for the transactional layer.	Formation only. Does not guide what to do before or after. No fundraising, hiring, validation, or PMF guidance. US-centric — limited support for international founders. No ongoing relationship.
Clerky *clerky.com / handbooks.clerky.com*	**Legal documents + handbook**	Attorney-quality documents at startup prices. SAFE templates, hiring docs, board consents, and a free Legal Concepts Handbook that is arguably the best plain-English startup legal resource on the internet.	Documents and education only. No workflow guidance. No onboarding, no fundraising guidance, no product advice. Clerky Handbook stops at legal formation.
Y Combinator Startup School *startupschool.org*	**Education + community**	Free curriculum with weekly accountability, co-founder matching, and the best canonical startup philosophy content. 45% of recent YC batches came through it. Paul Graham essays are the foundational canon.	Education only — no transactional execution, no legal formation, no document templates. Curriculum is linear and not personalised to a founder's stage or domain. No US-specific procedural guidance.
Carta *carta.com*	**Cap table + data**	Market-standard cap-table management for VC-backed startups. State of Private Markets quarterly data is the benchmark for fundraising statistics. Quarterly data is the most trusted benchmarking source in the ecosystem.	Cap table and fundraising data only. No guidance for pre-formation founders. No validation, MVP, or GTM content. Starts being relevant only after formation is complete and equity has been issued.
AngelList / Carta Stack *angellist.com*	**Fundraising infrastructur e**	Powers SPVs, rolling funds, venture syndicates, and SAFE management at scale. AngelList Stack bundles formation, banking, and fundraising for YC-model startups.	Infrastructure for established startups raising capital. Not a guide for first-time founders navigating from idea to incorporation. Investor-facing, not founder-education-facing.
Lenny's Newsletter / Podcast *lennysnewsletter.com*	**Product + growth guidance**	Opinionated, interview-based frameworks on PMF, growth loops, pricing, and hiring. Widely trusted by product-minded founders. The B2B startup playbook series is a model of sequential, sourced content.	PM and growth focus only. No legal, financial, or formation content. Paywalled. Not actionable for pre-product founders. A media product, not a guided workflow product.
SBA.gov / SCORE *sba.gov*	**Government resources**	Official US government guidance on business formation, loans (SBA 7(a), 504, Microloan), SBIR/STTR grants, and small-business compliance. Free, authoritative, comprehensive on traditional small business.	Designed for main-street small businesses, not venture-backed tech startups. LLC-first framing. No SAFE, no cap table, no equity, no PMF guidance. Bureaucratic UX. Outdated in parts.
First Round Review *review.firstround.com*	**Founder retr ospectives**	The highest-quality long-form founder interview content available. Deep dives on hiring, scaling, co-founder dynamics, fundraising, and PMF from founders who have lived it.	Pure editorial content — no workflow, no templates, no formation. Useful as a research source and as StartupKit editorial content; not useful as a product model.

The gap StartupKit fills: No existing product combines YC Startup School's educational arc with Stripe Atlas's transactional execution inside one guided, personalised workflow. Every product listed above solves one part of the journey. StartupKit's thesis is that the navigation layer connecting all of them — personalised, sequential, opinionated, sourced — is worth building and does not exist yet.

— SECTION 06

The Research Framework — Nine Domains

Sprint 1 research is organised into nine domains. Each domain has a defined scope, a primary source set, and a concrete output artifact. Together the nine artifacts constitute The Map — the substrate every future sprint draws from.

01

Stage Map

11-stage canonical journey with durations, milestones, and key outputs

Sources: YC Library · Paul Graham essays · Steve Blank · Eric Ries

02

Founder-Question Catalog

80–120 verbatim founder questions, each tagged to a stage and a domain

Sources: r/startups · Indie Hackers · HN Ask · YC Startup School forums · Quora

03

Validation Frameworks

Comparative guide: Mom Test, JTBD, Customer Development, Lean Startup

Sources: Mom Test (Fitzpatrick) · Steve Blank · Eric Ries · YC essays

04

Legal & Incorporation Reference

Procedural guide with dollar amounts, deadlines, form numbers

Sources: IRS.gov · corp.delaware.gov · Clerky Handbook · Cooley GO · Stripe Atlas Guides

05

Fundraising Landscape

Benchmark tables by stage + SAFEs + NVCA term-sheet primer

Sources: YC Documents · NVCA · Carta State of Private Markets · PitchBook

06

Statistics & Failure Data

Cited numbers ledger with source, date, and methodological note

Sources: BLS · CB Insights · Carta · Startup Genome · Crunchbase

07

Mistakes Catalog

Stage-tagged failure modes with consequences and avoidance tactics

Sources: PG '18 Mistakes' · CB Insights post-mortems · First Round Review

08

Source Tier List

Curated bibliography ranked by trust tier with bias and currency notes

Sources: Direct evaluation — see Section 11 of this document

09

Roadmap Product Design

Competitive teardown + six design principles for the eventual product

Sources: YC Startup School · Stripe Atlas · Clerky · Carta · Lenny's Newsletter

— SECTION 07

The Founder-Question Catalog

We do not invent the questions. We harvest them. The catalog is built by reading actual founder threads and writing each recurring question down verbatim, tagged to a stage. These questions are the routing logic for StartupKit's UI — every question maps to content, a tool, or a referral.

The target is 80–120 questions across all stages. Below is the starter set. Research should extend and verify this list, not treat it as final.

Ideation

? Should I find a co-founder before I have an idea, or after?
? How do I know if my idea is good enough to pursue?
? What if someone steals my idea?
? Should I do a startup in an industry I don't know?
? How do I come up with a startup idea?

Discovery & Validation

? How many user interviews are enough before I start building?
? How do I get honest feedback when people just want to be nice?
? What is the Mom Test and how do I use it?
? How do I find people to interview who aren't friends and family?
? What counts as 'validation'?

MVP & Build

? Should I use no-code or write real code for my MVP?
? How polished does the MVP need to be before launching?
? How do I decide what features to cut?
? Should I launch publicly or to a small group first?
? What does 'product-market fit' actually feel like?

Legal Formation

? LLC or C-Corp — which should I choose?
? Why Delaware? Can I just incorporate in my home state?
? What is an 83(b) election and do I need to file one?
? How should co-founders split equity?
? What is a PIIA and why does every employee need to sign one?
? What is a cap table and how do I set one up?

First Revenue

? How do I find my first 10 customers?
? How much should I charge?
? Should I do a free trial or charge from day one?
? What is a reasonable sales cycle for B2B?
? When do I need a proper contract vs. a handshake?

Hiring

- ? How much equity should employee #1 get? What about #5?
- ? Contractor vs full-time employee — what's the difference legally?
- ? What is the difference between an ISO and an NSO option?
- ? What is a 409A valuation and when do I need one?
- ? How do I legally hire someone in another country?

Fundraising

- ? What is a SAFE note? How is it different from a convertible note?
- ? What is a valuation cap and how does it work?
- ? What is the difference between pre-money and post-money SAFEs?
- ? How much should I raise at pre-seed?
- ? What do VCs actually look at before investing?
- ? What is an MFN clause?
- ? How do I find angel investors?
- ? What does YC's standard deal look like?

— SECTION 08

Legal & Formation Reference — USA

This section is the most fact-sensitive in the document. Every dollar amount, every deadline, every form number has a primary-source URL. Research must verify and extend this, not copy it.

Entity Selection — LLC vs C-Corp

Roughly **93% of VC-backed US startups are Delaware C-Corps.** The reason is structural: VC fund LPs include pension funds, endowments, and foreign investors who cannot receive pass-through income allocations from an LLC or S-Corp without phantom tax. C-Corps block this. S-Corps are additionally disqualified for VC because they cap shareholders at 100 and prohibit entity shareholders.

Delaware specifically dominates because of its specialised Court of Chancery, the standardisation of YC SAFEs and NVCA documents around the DGCL, and QSBS / Section 1202 access. The One Big Beautiful Bill Act (July 2025) raised the QSBS per-issuer exclusion cap from $10M to **$15M** and the gross-assets cap from $50M to $75M for stock issued after July 4, 2025.

The Delaware C-Corp Procedure

Name search	corp.delaware.gov — verify name availability ($10 search fee)
Certificate of Incorporation	Under 8 Del. C. §102 · Standard: 10,000,000 authorized at $0.0001 par · State fee from $89
Registered Agent	Required at all times · $50–$300/yr · Stripe Atlas, Clerky, CT Corporation, National Registered Agents
EIN (Federal Tax ID)	Form SS-4 · Free at IRS.gov · US founders: online Mon–Fri 7am–10pm ET · Foreign founders: fax SS-4 to +1 (855) 215-1627
Bylaws & Board Consent	Initial organisational board consent · Adopt bylaws · Appoint officers · Issue founder shares
Founder Stock & Vesting	4-year vest / 1-year cliff standard · Founders purchase at par ($0.0001/share) · Issue restricted stock
83(b) Election ■	File within 30 calendar days of stock grant · No extensions · No cure · Use IRS Form 15620 (released April 2025) · Certified mail with return receipt to IRS
Business Bank Account	Mercury, Brex (acquired by Capital One April 2026), Rho, or a chartered bank · Open immediately after EIN
Cap Table Tool	Carta (market leader) · Pulley (YC-backed) · AngelList Stack · Spreadsheet acceptable pre-seed only

Delaware Franchise Tax — the hidden bill

Delaware charges annual franchise tax, due **March 1**. There are two calculation methods. The **Authorized Shares method** (the default) produces a bill of $85,165+ for a standard 10M-share charter. Always use the **Assumed Par Value Capital (APV) method**, which typically produces $400–$800 for an early-stage startup. Source: corp.delaware.gov/frtaxcalc

IP Protection — PIIA and TAA

Every founder, employee, contractor, intern, and advisor must sign a **PIIA** (Proprietary Information and Inventions Assignment) *before doing any work*. The critical phrase is **'I hereby assign'** in present tense — not 'I will assign.' The Supreme Court in *Stanford v. Roche* (563 U.S. 776, 2011) held that future-tense assignments do not transfer title.

Founders must also sign a **TAA** (Technology Assignment Agreement) that assigns pre-incorporation IP — code, designs, customer lists built before the entity existed — to the company. Skipping the TAA is routinely discovered at Series A diligence and sometimes kills deals.

State-law carve-outs under California Labor Code §2870 and parallels in Washington, Minnesota, Utah, Illinois, Delaware, and North Carolina must be included in every PIIA, or it is unenforceable in those states.

Formation Service Pricing (2025–2026)

Service	Price	Covers	Best for
Stripe Atlas	$500 one-time + $100/yr RA	Filing, EIN, equity, 83(b), 1yr RA, guides	Non-US founders, speed
Clerky	$427 pay-per-use or $799 Lifetime	All docs + SAFE templates + hiring docs	YC-track, US founders
Firstbase	~$399 base	Filing, RA, EIN, banking links	Speed-focused, lean
DIY Direct	$89–$200 state fees	Filing only (you write all docs)	Not recommended

— SECTION 09

The Fundraising Landscape — 2025–2026 Benchmarks

All numbers from Carta State of Private Markets, PitchBook, and YC. Every benchmark carries a date because these move quarterly.

Benchmark Table by Stage (Carta Q3–Q4 2025)

Stage	Median Raise	Pre-Money	Post-Money	Dilution	Instrument
Pre-seed	$750K–$1.5M	$7.7M (PitchBook Q3'25)	$6–10M SAFE cap	15–20%	Post-money SAFE (~92%)
Seed	$3.1M (all); $4.6M AI/health	$16M (record Q3'25)	$20–24M (record Q4'25)	~20%	SAFE or priced seed
Series A	$10–15M	$48–49M (record Q3'25)	$57–78M (record Q4'25)	17.9% (Q1'25, down from 20.9%)	Priced preferred, NVCA docs
Series B	$30–40M	$100–130M	$120–160M	~15%	Priced preferred, NVCA docs

SAFE Notes — the dominant pre-seed instrument

SAFEs were authored by YC's Carolynn Levy in 2013. The 2018 switch to **post-money SAFE** locks investor ownership at signing (Investment ÷ Post-Money Cap), making dilution predictable but pushing it onto founders rather than earlier SAFE holders. Post-money SAFEs are now ~83–91% of all SAFEs (Carta 2025). Five official YC variants are available at **ycombinator.com/documents**.

Key SAFE terms to understand: **valuation cap** (the maximum price at which SAFE converts), **discount** (almost always 20% when present), **MFN** (most-favoured-nation — lets uncapped SAFE holder swap into best subsequent terms), and **pro-rata rights** (preserve investor ownership in future rounds).

YC and Techstars — current standard deals

Y Combinator (as of Jan 2022, stable): $500,000 total — $125,000 on a post-money SAFE at a fixed 7% (implied cap ~$1.78M) + $375,000 on an uncapped MFN SAFE, with a pro-rata side letter. Deal page: ycombinator.com/deal. Acceptance rate ~1%.

Techstars (changed Fall 2025): $220,000 total — $20,000 in convertible equity for 5% common stock + $200,000 on an uncapped MFN SAFE. Previously $120,000 for 6%. Source: TechCrunch, April 2025.

The Series A crunch — what the data says

Only **15.4% of 2022-vintage seed-stage companies raised a Series A within two years** (Carta 2025). The seed-to-A wait has stretched to a median of **25 months**. A-to-B wait is now 2.8 years, both the longest on record. CRV's 2026 benchmark for Series A readiness is **$2.5M ARR with strong NRR and a clear growth path**. This context shapes every fundraising decision a pre-Series-A founder makes.

— SECTION 10

The Mistakes Catalog — Stage-Tagged Failure Modes

Every failure mode below is tagged to the stage where it most commonly occurs. In StartupKit's product, these surface at the moment they threaten the user — not in a generic warning blob. Sources: Paul Graham 'The 18 Mistakes That Kill Startups', CB Insights post-mortem library, Startup Genome.

Stage	Mistake	Consequence	How to avoid
Ideation	**Derivative ideas ('Twitter for X')**	No differentiation; commoditised on launch	Start from a personal pain, not a template
Ideation	**Avoiding competition by choosing small markets**	The niche is small because it's bad, not because it's undiscovered	Competition signals demand; enter with a clear wedge
Discovery	**Skipping customer interviews**	Build something nobody wants; #1 startup killer per CB Insights (42%)	Do 20 Mom Test-style interviews before writing code
Discovery	**Leading questions**	Confirmation bias; false validation	Ask about past behaviour, not hypothetical future intent
Formation	**Missing 83(b) deadline**	Multi-million phantom income tax on unvested stock	File within 30 days; use IRS Form 15620; certified mail
Formation	**LLC when planning to raise VC**	$10–35K conversion costs + QSBS clock reset + LP tax issues	Default to Delaware C-Corp if any VC raise is possible
Formation	**Equal equity split without conversation**	Co-founder conflict at first sign of stress	Use a vesting schedule; have the equity conversation explicitly
Formation	**No TAA signed by founders**	Pre-incorporation IP stays with the individual; kills Series A diligence	TAA signed at formation; covers all pre-company IP
MVP	**Launching too slowly**	Competitor ships first; founder loses momentum	Paul Graham: 'Launch when you would be embarrassed'
Hiring	**Hiring too early after a raise**	Burn rate spikes before PMF; forced to cut team	Series A teams now avg 16.8 people — stay lean
Hiring	**Hiring VP Sales before repeatable motion**	Premature scaling; Genome: 74% of failures	Hire sales doers; founder sells until the process is repeatable
Fundraising	**Raising at too-high a valuation**	Preference overhang; down-round psychology; investor misalignment	Raise at a price you can grow into within 18 months
Fundraising	**Treating SAFE cap as a valuation**	Founders sign away equity they didn't intend to	Understand conversion math; model cap table before signing
Scaling	**Premature scaling (74% failure cause)**	Burn rate outpaces learning; organisation breaks before PMF	Startup Genome: scale operations only after validated learning

— SECTION 11

Source Tier List — What to Trust

Three tiers. Every research output must cite from Tier 1 wherever possible, use Tier 2 for context, and treat Tier 3 only as a pointer to a real source — never as the citation itself.

Tier 1 — Always Trust, Cite Directly

- Y Combinator Startup Library (ycombinator.com/library) and SAFE documents (ycombinator.com/documents)
- Paul Graham essays (paulgraham.com/articles.html) — especially: How to Get Startup Ideas, Do Things That Don't Scale, The 18 Mistakes, How to Raise Money
- IRS.gov — Form SS-4, Form 1120, Form 15620 (83b, released April 2025), Publication 15
- SBA.gov — business guides, SBIR/STTR, loan programs
- Delaware Division of Corporations (corp.delaware.gov) — franchise tax calculator, name search
- Clerky Handbook (handbooks.clerky.com) — the gold standard for plain-English startup legal text
- Cooley GO document generators (cooleygo.com/documents)
- Stripe Atlas Guides (stripe.com/atlas/guides)
- NVCA Model Legal Documents (nvca.org/model-legal-documents) — revised October 2025
- Sequoia 'Writing a Business Plan' (sequoiacap.com)
- First Round Review (review.firstround.com)
- Steve Blank (steveblank.com), a16z Startup Metrics (a16z.com/16-startup-metrics)
- Books: The Mom Test · The Lean Startup · Zero to One · Venture Deals · Secrets of Sand Hill Road

Tier 2 — Good, Verify Before Citing

- Carta blog and State of Private Markets data — great proprietary data; commentary is incentive-aligned; always note 'as-of' date
- AngelList blog — excellent on mechanics they administer
- Lenny's Newsletter — top-tier PM/growth content; paywalled; PM-lens, not legal-lens
- a16z thought-leadership (versus their metrics primers which are Tier 1)
- Sector-specific VC blogs — Bessemer, USV, partner personal blogs
- Crunchbase and PitchBook data — paywalled samples; methodology varies; note in citation

Tier 3 — Community / Anecdotal. Use to Find Sources, Never to Cite

- Hacker News, Indie Hackers, r/startups, r/Entrepreneur, r/SaaS, r/venturecapital
- Twitter/X founder threads
- Generic Medium and Substack posts without primary citations
- Incorporation-service or bank vendor blogs (Mercury, Brex, Stripe Atlas blogs are Tier 2 exception)
- Wikipedia

— SECTION 12 · THE FINISH LINE

Definition of Done — Sprint 1

Sprint 1 is complete when — and only when — all seven artifacts below exist, have been peer-reviewed, and carry an 'as-of' date in their headers. The convergence meeting on Day 15 is where all research is presented, conflicts are resolved, and one agreed Map is produced.

01 **Canonical 11-Stage Map**
Durations, key activities, milestone outputs, and key decisions for each stage. Peer-reviewed against YC, Steve Blank, and Lean Startup canon. Conflicts resolved and noted.

02 **Founder-Question Catalog**
80–120 verbatim founder questions. Each tagged to one or more stages and one or more domains. Harvested from named sources — r/startups, HN, YC forums, Indie Hackers. Not invented.

03 **Validation Frameworks Guide**
Covers Mom Test, JTBD, Customer Development, Lean Startup, and YC tactical overlay. At least one primary-source citation per framework. Decision matrix mapping risks to MVP types.

04 **Legal & Incorporation Reference**
Specific dollar amounts, deadlines, form numbers for: entity selection, Delaware incorporation, IRS/EIN, 83(b) with Form 15620, cap-table mechanics, PIIA/TAA, state nexus, banking. Every claim sourced to IRS.gov, corp.delaware.gov, Clerky, Cooley GO, or Stripe Atlas.

05 **Fundraising Landscape Brief**
Current benchmark tables by stage (Carta Q4 2025). Deep dives on post-money SAFEs and convertible notes. NVCA term-sheet primer. Current YC and Techstars deal terms. Investor ladder. Non-dilutive alternatives.

06 **Statistics Ledger + Mistakes Catalog**
Every cite-worthy number with source URL, date, and methodological note. Stage-tagged mistakes catalog drawing from PG '18 Mistakes', CB Insights, and Genome.

07 **Source Tier List**
Tier 1/2/3 with all sources in this document catalogued. Must-read entries per source. Bias and currency caveats noted. Research team has read at least one Tier 1 source per domain.

The Day 15 Convergence Meeting. Every researcher presents their domain brief. Where 4 of 5 researchers agree on a step or fact — it goes in. Where there is conflict — the group discusses and decides. By end of Day 15, there is ONE agreed Map that is the foundation of every future sprint. Sprint 1 does not end with a build. It ends with confidence that when StartupKit ships a flow, every word in it traces back to a Tier-1 source and every recommendation reflects a deliberate choice we can defend to a founder, an investor, or a litigator.

The map matters more than the territory — what matters is that the map is opinionated, sourced, current, and structured around the questions founders actually ask.

tensorfold.ai · StartupKit · Sprint 1: The Map · Internal Document · 2026